Building without permission in the age of AI

About me

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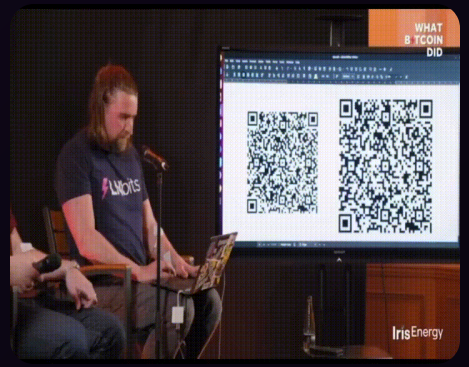


A brief history of free and open-source

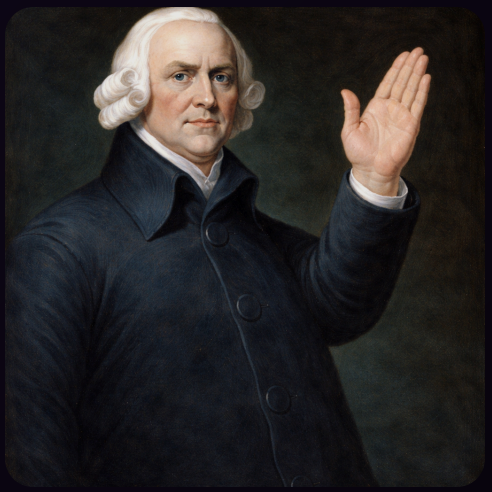
- **1970s** “Sharing culture”
  Homebrew Computer Club (pre–open source)
- **1976:** Bill Gates, “An Open Letter to Hobbyists”
  “People copying software is stealing”
- **1983:** GNU Project (Richard Stallman)
  1985: GNU GPL v1
  - Must share source
  - Keeps software open
  - Requires attribution
- **1987:** MIT License (Massachusetts Institute of Technology)
  - Do anything (even use in closed software)
  - Just keep attribution

> Software as knowledge not property

FOSS as the commons

- Bitcoin and Nostr require no permission
- Open protocols keep capital answerable to users
- Adam Smith Invisible Bitch Slap (Ben™)
- Closed platforms lock people in, enshittify, push users to FOSS

> Nurture the commons and get rewarded, exploit it and get a slap



The good: vibe coding

BUILD LIKE IT'S 1975 🎵

- Culture of building again
- Gonzo developing (Ben™)
- Cost of producing software is low (allegedly)

Doomer time...

The bad: hype, myth, limitations

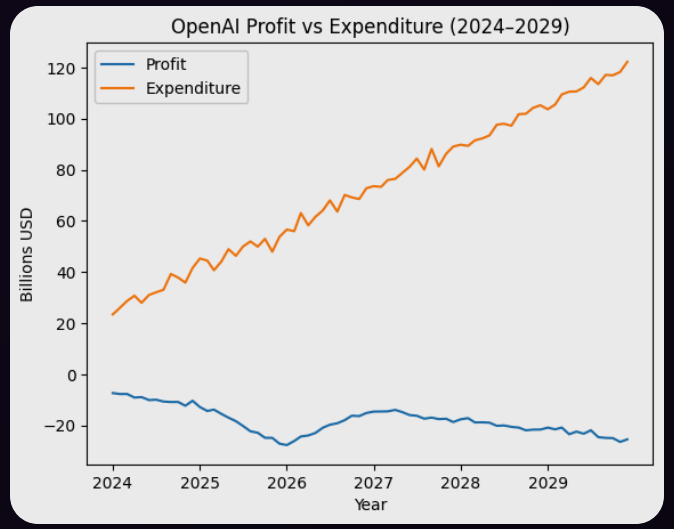
- Licensing implications + code theft
  - Licenses matter!
- !context === slop. Agents get dumb fast
- Turing hype: LLMs are great at sounding clever
- AI hallucinates and is unpredictable
- VC/CEO crack - dump workforce, force useless "AI" products on customers

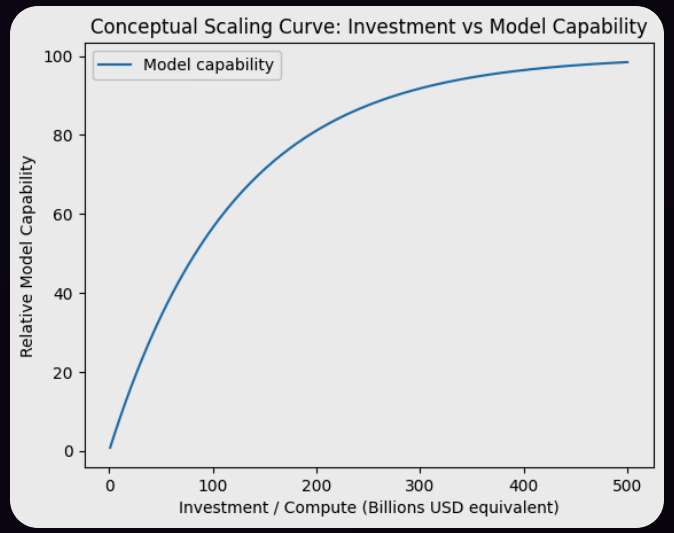
Risk	Result
License breach	Everyone sues each other
AI over-pumped	Later market correction
Skill atrophy	Bleed engineering talent

The ugly: AI industry is a huge bubble

- Unsustainable AI business models (current 10x discount before profit)
- AGI promise built on sand/assumptions (enough power then AGI)
- Rising energy/resource costs
- Capital intensity problem facing frontier AI companies
- Gov tax breaks
- Slow/expensive infrastructure rollout
- If/when promises are kept capitalism breaks

Risk	Result
Poor AI economics	Users won't pay actual cost
AI plateaus	VCs lose return/hyper-enshittification
Industry buckles under own falsehoods	AI development grinds to a halt





Reality

- Make hay while the sun shines 👷
- Don't bleed engineers
- Build like it's 1975
- **context**, **context**, **context** ideas are scarce, tokens are unrealistically cheap

> Replacing a developer with AI is like replacing a carpenter with a hammer

Adjusting to current reality

- **API is the UI for AI**
- Some systems should stay dumb, narrow, and predictable
- Be mindful we are in a blip that could pop
- We still exist in a world of friction, removing friction has value
- Engineers are not paid just to type code
- AI is weak outside the training set
- Humans have huge context advantages

Closing thought

- Open platforms are preferred by AI and builders
- Build as much as you can now
- The advantage still comes from **tools, context, and taste**

> The future belongs to people who can use powerful tools without giving up understanding.